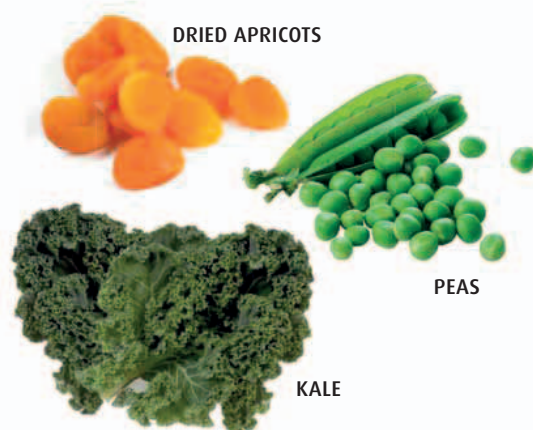


Q Should I take an iron supplement in case I become anemic?

It is usually better to get your iron needs from your diet. This is because iron supplements can have the side effect of causing constipation, which pregnant women are already susceptible to. Eating iron-rich, high-fiber foods is good for tackling both constipation and low iron levels. Include more lean red meat, green leafy vegetables, nuts such as peanuts, and dried fruit in your diet. It's usual during pregnancy to feel more tired than normal, particularly in the first and last trimesters. However, if you are extremely lethargic, pale, and suffering from heart palpitations and/or shortness of breath, you could be anemic. If you are, your doctor will discuss iron supplementation. In addition, consider cutting out caffeine entirely since this can hamper iron absorption.



Iron-rich foods Dried apricots, peas, and leafy vegetables such as kale are great sources of iron. Vitamin C helps with iron absorption, so drink orange juice with your meal.

Q Do I need to take a multivitamin supplement now that I am pregnant?

The most important supplement you need to take is folic acid. Health-care professionals advise a vitamin D supplement (10mcg daily) to help your body metabolize calcium for the benefit of maintaining your own bones and teeth as well as your baby's developing bones. The other elements in a multivitamin supplement aren't strictly essential if you are eating a balanced diet. If you do choose to take a supplement, make sure it is right for pregnancy. Never take a supplement containing vitamin A, since too much can harm your baby.

Q Could my weight affect my chances of having a healthy pregnancy?

Unfortunately, being either obese or underweight can have a negative impact on both your ability to conceive and your health in pregnancy. If you can, take action to make sure your weight is within healthy limits before getting pregnant.

It is best to achieve a healthy weight before you think about conception. For both partners, you need a certain level of body fat to produce the right levels of hormones for healthy sperm production and ovulation to occur. In obese people, excess estrogen can decrease sperm levels and hamper or even prevent ovulation, while underweight people can have too little fat in their bodies to conceive. If you are underweight, there is a

greater risk of your baby having a low birthweight or being premature. Gain and maintain weight healthily by eating an extra 200–300 calories a day until your weight improves. During pregnancy, obesity can affect the health of your baby, and it is known to increase the risk of conditions such as gestational diabetes and preeclampsia (see pp.144–45)—factors that can cause complications during pregnancy and the birth.

BODY MASS INDEX (BMI) CHART

This chart is appropriate for women over the age of 18. Body mass index (BMI) gauges whether you are a healthy weight in relation to your height. A BMI of 30 or more is considered obese, while a BMI of less than 18.5 is deemed underweight.

